> might undertake . . . I was as much gratified as surprised to witness the good sense displayed by the young sirdar as to the nature of my researches, and their object. He remarked to those about him, who suggested that I might be seeking treasure, that my only purpose was to advance science, which would lead to my credit on my return to my native country; and he observed, that whilst among Durranis the soldier was held in honour, amongst Europeans respect was paid to men of 'illam' or science.[49]

Another European traveller, Godfrey Vigne, also described Akbar as the most progressive, enquiring and intelligent of all the Afghan nobles. He closely questioned Vigne on the taste of pork, forbidden to all good Muslims, and was 'so far from being a bigot that he several times ordered his servant to hand me water from his own cup', at a time when most Afghans refused to eat or drink with Christians.[50]

The following day, Akbar Khan led Burnes into Kabul on elephant-back. 'We were received with great pomp and splendour,' wrote Burnes. 'He did me the honour to place me on the same elephant upon which he himself rode, and conducted us to his father's court, whose reception of me was most cordial. A spacious garden, close by the palace and inside the Bala Hisar of Kabul, was allotted to the mission as their place of residence.'[51]

Burnes was received in full durbar by his old friend Amir Dost Mohammad the following morning. As before, Burnes's charm soon won over the Amir. Even though Dost Mohammad charged the British with duplicity in aiding Shah Shuja, and with knowing in advance of Ranjit Singh's plan to seize Peshawar, he had clearly decided not to let this interfere with his friendship with Burnes. Moreover, he calculated that opening diplomatic relations with Britain was his best hope of outflanking the Sikhs. Before long the two men were on the same warm terms as before, and Burnes as admiring of his host as he had been in 1831. 'Power frequently spoils men,' he wrote, 'but with Dost Muhammad neither the increase of it, nor his new title of Amir, seems to have done him any harm. Instead he seems even more alert and full of intelligence than when I last saw him.' When Burnes was led into the audience hall and formally presented his credentials and his slightly disappointing presents, Dost Mohammad received them politely. 'I informed him that I had brought with me, as presents to his Highness, some of the rarities of Europe: he promptly replied that we ourselves were the rarities, the sight of which best pleased him.'[52]

Later, Burnes reflected perceptively on this meeting: